JR STRENGTH & FITNESS

FREE RESOURCE / FOR COACHES

THE EXERCISE SELECTION BLUEPRINT

RIGHT EXERCISE, RIGHT PERSON.

A coach's framework for choosing exercises. Eight ways to read an exercise, six ways to read the person and the program, one decision process, and a card that puts it to work on your next client.



FROM THE FLOOR

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Director of Personal Training, Timberhill Athletic Club
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20,000 HOURS

Coaching on the floor, 10+ years

THE DECISION | THE EXERCISE | THE PERSON | THE PROCESS | IAOE | THE CARD

THE DECISION

THE EXERCISE IS NOT THE DECISION.

This is a coach's decision system, not a ranking. It won't tell you the best exercise. It will help you show why an exercise is the right call for this person, right now.

A WORKOUT IS A LIST OF EXERCISES. COACHING IS THE DECISION-MAKING BEHIND THE LIST.

Exercise characteristics are real, and you can describe them. What they're worth depends on the person, the goal and the program around them. You need both to make the call.

NO EXERCISE HAS A CONTEXT-FREE SCORE. "Better" always means better for a defined purpose. A comparison needs an outcome and a criterion.

START WITH THE SIMPLEST EFFECTIVE OPTION. Add complexity when it buys something you can name. Adequate is a win.

JUDGE THE CALL WITH WHAT YOU KNEW THEN. A reasonable decision can still miss. Grade the reasoning against the information you had, then adjust.

THE DECISION

ONE LINE. EIGHT DECISIONS.

One line on the client's program sheet, and the decisions behind it.

B · LEG PRESS · 3 × 10	WHAT THE COACH DECIDED
OUTCOME	Improve lower-body strength and muscular development.
PERFORMANCE MARKER	Leg press performance at a consistent rep target, range of motion, execution standard and effort.
LONGER-TERM EVALUATION	Muscular development judged with other indicators where practical, such as landmarked girths, alongside the performance trend.
TARGET	Quads and glutes. The emphasis depends on foot position and depth.
PERSON	Limited ankle range. Still learning to balance under load.
WHY THIS ONE	Supported, easy to load in small jumps, few cues to manage.
HOW IT FITS	Placed first, while they're fresh. Ankle work rides alongside.
WHAT I WATCH	Depth they control, knee path, and the performance trend over four weeks.

THE EXERCISE

UNDERSTAND THE EXERCISE.

Eight domains help us examine the mechanical, physiological and practical characteristics of an exercise: what it offers, what it demands, and what may limit its effectiveness.

Those characteristics aren't entirely fixed. Equipment, setup, execution, range of motion, loading and individual anthropometry can influence the demands the person experiences. The coach's job is to understand them, identify which ones matter for the intended adaptation, and decide whether they fit the individual and the program. Not every domain deserves equal consideration: prioritize the domains most relevant to the intended adaptation and the individual's circumstances. **Understand the exercise first. Then determine its application.**

WHERE THE RESEARCH STANDS

STABILITY [1]. A position stand concluded that unstable bases can reduce force, power, velocity and range of motion, and didn't recommend them as the main mode of athletic conditioning.

LOAD [2]. With sets taken to failure, hypertrophy was similar across a wide range of loads; 1RM strength favored heavier loads. Protocol and population matter.

RANGE AND LENGTH [4]. Full range edged out partial range by trivial-to-small margins, mostly when strength was tested through full range. Growth was similar. Any benefit of lengthened partials is still uncertain.

THE EXERCISE

EIGHT DOMAINS.

Not every domain deserves equal consideration. Prioritize the domains most relevant to the intended adaptation and the individual's circumstances.

BIOMECHANICAL

Joint actions, moment arms, muscle contributions, joint torque demand, range of motion and muscle length.

Where does this put the stress, and can this client use that range today?

PHYSIOLOGICAL

Local muscular, neural, metabolic and systemic demand, and how sets, reps, effort, rest and order change them.

Is the demand landing on the target, or spread across the body?

RESISTANCE

How external resistance and mechanical demand change through the movement, including modality and setup.

Where is it hardest, and does that matter for this goal?

FATIGUE

Local and systemic fatigue, what limits the set, the recovery cost and what it means for the rest of the program.

What will end the set, and what will it cost the rest of the week?

STABILITY

Base of support, external support, balance and coordination, and how much stabilizing the lifter has to do.

Is balance serving the goal, or has it become the limiter?

Stability is a dial, not a virtue.

EXECUTION

Technical complexity, motor control, range consistency, learning demand and rep-to-rep repeatability.

Can this client repeat it well with one or two cues?

LOADING

Loading capacity, room to progress, increment size, repeatability and how well it can be measured.

Can I load and progress it without changing the stimulus?

Load is a means, not the goal.

PRACTICAL

Equipment, access, setup, time, tracking, efficiency, and whether it can actually be implemented.

Is the payoff worth the setup, and will they stick with it?

THE PERSON AND THE PROGRAM

UNDERSTAND THE PERSON.

Six things the exercise can't tell you. This is where the same exercise becomes the right call for one client and the wrong one for another.

THE EXERCISE. Eight domains, page 5. What it does.

THE PERSON AND PROGRAM. Six domains, this page. Who it's for and where it sits.

THE DECISION. Made from both, then graded with IAOE on page 9.

GOALS AND DESIRED ADAPTATION

Turn "I want to get stronger" into something you can measure: strength output, muscle, skill or performance, bone loading, or a process goal that supports one of those. Preferences belong here too.

An exercise the client dislikes and skips has a low ceiling.

EXPERIENCE AND COMPETENCY

Skill, body awareness, and whether they understand why the exercise is there.

Technical complexity is not a compulsory progression milestone.

CAPABILITIES AND LIMITATIONS

Movement capacity, joint tolerance, mobility, stability and restrictions. Work around a limitation so training stays productive, and improve it at the same time.

A limitation doesn't mean avoiding productive training.

RECOVERY AND READINESS

Sleep, stress, soreness, how fresh the muscle is, motivation. Interpret it relative to the phase.

Some fatigue is expected in a demanding block.

PHASE AND PRIORITIES

Accumulation leans on volume, controlled tension and local stimulus. Intensification leans on load, force and performance. A deload manages fatigue and keeps what matters.

My approach, not a law.

PROGRAMMING INTEGRATION

Order, what comes before and after, weekly workload, schedule and adherence. Exercises done earlier in a session tend to get more reps and gain more strength [3, 5]. Order has shown little effect on growth [5]. Priorities go first.

A session the client can't attend isn't effective. Every exercise uses time something else could have.

THE PROCESS

SIX STEPS. ONE LOOP.

The first pass runs top to bottom. After that, what you observe sends you back to the prescription or the selection.

1

DEFINE THE OUTCOME

What measurable result matters right now?

2

IDENTIFY THE TARGET

Which muscle, movement or quality has to be trained?

3

EVALUATE THE INDIVIDUAL

Capabilities, limitations, experience, preferences and readiness.

4

COMPARE EXERCISE OPTIONS

Weigh only the characteristics that matter for this decision.

> **If no option fits, change the variant, setup, modality or regression and compare again.**

5

INTEGRATE AND PRESCRIBE

Order, phase, load, range, sets, reps, rest, execution and progression.

6

OBSERVE, EVALUATE, ADJUST

Execution, tolerance, adherence, performance and fatigue.

> **Prescription problem: back to 5. Poorly matched exercise: back to 4. Changed objective or target: back to 1 or 2. If it's doing its job, keep it and progress it.**

THE PROCESS, APPLIED

THE OBJECTIVE HASN'T CHANGED. THE CLIENT HAS.

Illustrative scenario, not a documented case.

Poor sleep, a stressful week and unusually high fatigue, on a day the plan calls for a heavily loaded squat.

OUTCOME. Continue productive lower-body training.

TARGET. Keep the intended muscular stimulus without unnecessary demand.

INDIVIDUAL. Today's readiness may limit performance and tolerance.

OPTIONS. The planned squat, an adjusted squat prescription, a supported squat, or a leg press.

PRESCRIPTION. Adjust the exercise, load, effort or volume as needed.

REASSESSMENT. Watch execution, performance, symptoms and recovery.

Cancelling or swapping the squat isn't automatic. First decide whether the original prescription still fits. A lower-demand option only helps if it still serves the purpose.

READINESS MAY CHANGE THE PRESCRIPTION WITHOUT CHANGING THE OBJECTIVE.

IAOE

GRADE THE DECISION, NOT THE EXERCISE.

IAOE is how I judge whether a selection was appropriate. It's a coaching decision framework, not a validated measurement instrument, and it never ranks exercises.

INADEQUATE. Fails a critical requirement of the individual, objective or program: the intended stimulus, execution capability, tolerance, or an essential practical constraint.

ADEQUATE. Meets the necessary standard. An appropriate, effective and sustainable path toward the objective. **Adequate is a win.**

OPTIMAL. A particularly favorable match between the intended adaptation, the individual, the exercise and the program. It doesn't mean complex or theoretically perfect.

ENHANCED. Adds justified precision, monitoring or refinement that produces meaningful value beyond what's already being achieved. It isn't automatically better than Optimal.

NOT A SCORE. You don't add points across the eight domains. One critical mismatch can make an otherwise reasonable decision Inadequate.

JUDGE WITH WHAT YOU KNEW. New information means reassess. It isn't proof the original decision was incompetent.

IAOE, APPLIED

ADEQUATE DOESN'T REQUIRE IMPROVEMENT.

A contextual illustration, not a set of compulsory stages.

A client can reliably train twice a week. The program is simple, execution is consistent and performance is progressing. A four-day program would offer more scheduling and volume options, but the client can't consistently fit in four sessions.

INADEQUATE. Prescribing four mandatory sessions knowing the client can't sustain them.

ADEQUATE. A repeatable two-day program with enough stimulus to keep progress measurable.

OPTIMAL. Refining the two days around their priorities, recovery and exercise tolerance, when a meaningful opportunity exists.

ENHANCED. Adding monitoring or prescription precision only when a specific need justifies the effort.

That same reasoning applies to exercise selection. A familiar, effective exercise the client can execute and progress consistently may be more appropriate than a technically sophisticated alternative that adds demands without meaningful benefit.

IF THE PRESCRIPTION IS EFFECTIVE, APPROPRIATE AND SUSTAINABLE, DON'T MANUFACTURE A PROBLEM TO SOLVE. ADEQUATE IS A WIN.

APPLIED COMPARISON

TWO OPTIONS, ONE CLIENT.

A hypothetical novice client, to show the reasoning. Neither option is better in general. The call on the next page is for this client.

The client. Wants lower-body strength and muscle. Limited ankle range, loses balance when loaded standing, little training experience. Early accumulation block, three sessions a week, and the gym has a leg press. Hypothetical; no result is claimed.

FOR THIS CLIENT	FREE-STANDING BACK SQUAT	LEG PRESS
BIOMECHANICAL	Limited ankle range may restrict depth, or change how they get there.	Seat and a higher foot position can ease ankle demand within a range they control.
STABILITY	Balance can become the limiter and end the set before the legs are worked hard.	External support may reduce balance and trunk stabilization as limiting factors, so the set is more likely to end from lower-body fatigue.
LOADING	Load may be capped by balance and technique more than by leg strength.	Small, repeatable load jumps make progress easier to track.
EXECUTION	Many things to manage at once for a novice: brace, bar path, balance, depth.	Fewer things to coordinate: depth, foot pressure, knee path, lower back stays down.
FATIGUE	Adds trunk and coordination demand. Worth it when standing strength is the goal.	May reduce some trunk and coordination demands. Total fatigue still depends on loading, effort, volume, execution and the individual.

APPLIED COMPARISON

THE CALL FOR THIS CLIENT.

Same hypothetical novice client as the previous page.

STABILITY IS A VARIABLE, NOT A PROGRESSION LADDER			More stabilization demand isn't automatically more advanced.
LEG PRESS	SMITH MACHINE SQUAT	GOBLET SQUAT	BARBELL BACK SQUAT
Most external support. Small load jumps. Low balance demand.	Standing, on a guided bar path. Moderate support.	Free and front-loaded. Squat pattern practice. Load capped by holding the weight.	Free bar, more coordination and trunk demand. More specific to free-bar back-squat performance [6].

Move between them when the objective or the client's capabilities justify it.

SELECTION. Leg press as the main loaded lower-body exercise, placed first in the session, with ankle mobility and squat practice to a box alongside it.

IAOE CALL. Optimal for this client, in this phase. For a trained lifter who needs standing strength, it might only be Adequate.

IF THE LEG PRESS STALLS. That isn't automatically a reason to change exercises. First check adherence, effort, execution, loading, range, volume, recovery and the phase objective.

CHANGE THE EXERCISE WHEN. The selection itself is the limiting factor, or a different option offers a meaningful advantage.

THE CARD

THE DECISION CARD.

The Exercise Selection Decision Card. One card per decision. Print it, or type straight into this page. If a box is empty, identify what's missing and determine whether it materially affects the decision.

CLIENT REFERENCE private ID, not a name

DATE

TRAINING PHASE

OUTCOME what measurable result matters now

TARGET muscle, movement or quality

CLIENT CONSIDERATIONS capacity, limits, experience, preferences, schedule, readiness

	CANDIDATE EXERCISE	KEY CHARACTERISTICS	PROGRAMMING FIT
OPTION A			
OPTION B			
OPTION C			

SELECTION AND RATIONALE why this one, for this person, now, and why that IAOE level

IAOE DECISION ☐ Inadequate ☐ Adequate ☐ Optimal ☐ Enhanced

REASSESSMENT TRIGGER what would make you change it

REVIEW DATE OR CONDITION

WORKED EXAMPLE

A COMPLETED CARD.

Illustrative Case A, general population. A hypothetical worked example. No client result is claimed.

CLIENT REFERENCE

Case A (hypothetical)

DATE

Week 1, session 1

TRAINING PHASE

Accumulation

OUTCOME

Lower-body hypertrophy with measurable progression.

TARGET

Quadriceps-focused knee-extension stimulus.

CLIENT CONSIDERATIONS

Limited training experience. Inconsistent balance under load. Reliable two-day schedule. Can perform supported lower-body exercises through a tolerable range.

	CANDIDATE EXERCISE	KEY CHARACTERISTICS	PROGRAMMING FIT
OPTION A	**Back squat**	Greater squat-specific technical demand; trunk stabilization demand; balance and coordination may limit this client.	Not preferred as the primary hypertrophy exercise at this stage.
OPTION B	**Leg press**	External support; repeatable setup; adjustable loading; lower balance demand.	Strong fit as the primary lower-body exercise.
OPTION C	**Supported split squat**	Unilateral loading; adjustable support; builds single-leg control and strength.	Useful complementary exercise.

SELECTION

Leg press, with a consistent setup, controlled range of motion and progressive loading.

RATIONALE

A practical way to load the target muscles while reducing balance as a limiting factor.

IAOE DECISION ☐ Inadequate ☐ Adequate ■ **Optimal, provisional** ☐ Enhanced

Appears especially well matched to the current objective and constraints. Confirm through observed execution, tolerance, adherence and progress.

REASSESSMENT TRIGGER

Persistent inability to progress after reviewing effort, loading, volume, adherence and recovery; a change in goals; or poor exercise tolerance.

REVIEW DATE OR CONDITION

After four weeks of logged sessions, or sooner if a trigger appears.

APPLIED COMPARISON

TWO DEFENSIBLE DECISIONS. DIFFERENT PRIORITIES.

An experienced client, hypertrophy focus, accumulation phase. Both lifts can contribute. Neither is automatically superior.

	BARBELL SQUAT	LEG PRESS
CHOOSE IT WHEN THE COACH ALSO VALUES	Squat-specific strength, technical proficiency, continued exposure to loaded standing movement, and the squat's role in the wider program.	Lower-body muscular loading, less demand on squat-specific coordination, less trunk stabilization, and a practical way to distribute training stress.
WHAT IT COSTS	More coordination and trunk demand. Sets can be limited by factors other than the target muscles.	Less squat-specific practice. Removing squats entirely is a trade-off if squat performance still matters.

Weigh the objective, the phase, the intended stimulus, the client's execution, the rest of the program, recovery and opportunity cost. Both choices could be Adequate. One may be Optimal for the context. Enhanced would need added precision that brings meaningful value.

THE COACH'S JOB IS NOT TO DEFEND A FAVORITE EXERCISE. IT IS TO DEFEND THE DECISION.

APPLIED COMPARISON

THE DECISION, GIVEN THE CONTEXT.

Hypothetical teaching scenario, not a documented client.

Accumulation phase focused on lower-body hypertrophy. The client already does demanding hip-hinge work and loaded unilateral exercises elsewhere in the week. Free-bar squat performance isn't a current priority. Squat sets are often limited by trunk fatigue before the intended lower-body stimulus is reached, even after adjusting reps, rest and setup. The client tolerates the leg press well and executes it consistently.

DECISION. I would select the leg press as the primary quadriceps-focused exercise for this phase.

RATIONALE. Not because the leg press is a universally superior hypertrophy exercise [6]. Because of the objective, the surrounding workload, the client's limiting factors, and the chance to load the target muscles with less squat-specific technical and balance demand.

WHAT I WOULD MONITOR. Execution and range consistency, progression in load and reps, effort against the prescription, local tolerance, recovery between sessions, and whether the exercise still fills its role.

WHAT WOULD CHANGE IT. If squat strength becomes a priority, add appropriate squat exposure. If the leg press stops providing the stimulus, can't be progressed or creates tolerance problems, reassess the prescription and then the selection.

IAOE. Optimal, provisionally, for this context. Both exercises could be Adequate; the leg press is the more favorable match to the current priorities and constraints. Subject to observed execution, tolerance and response.

THE RESEARCH

REFERENCES.

Bracketed numbers mark research. Everything else is my coaching interpretation or my own method.

[1] Behm DG, Drinkwater EJ, Willardson JM, Cowley PM; Canadian Society for Exercise Physiology. Canadian Society for Exercise Physiology position stand: the use of instability to train the core in athletic and nonathletic conditioning. *Appl Physiol Nutr Metab.* 2010;35(1):109–112. doi:10.1139/H09-128.

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[3] Simão R, de Salles BF, Figueiredo T, Dias I, Willardson JM. Exercise order in resistance training. *Sports Med.* 2012;42(3):251–265. doi:10.2165/11597240-000000000-00000.

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[5] Nunes JP, Grgic J, Cunha PM, Ribeiro AS, Schoenfeld BJ, de Salles BF, Cyrino ES. What influence does resistance exercise order have on muscular strength gains and muscle hypertrophy? A systematic review and meta-analysis. *Eur J Sport Sci.* 2021;21(2):149–157. doi:10.1080/17461391.2020.1733672.

[6] Haugen ME, Vårvik FT, Larsen S, Haugen AS, van den Tillaar R, Bjørnsen T. Effect of free-weight vs. machine-based strength training on maximal strength, hypertrophy and jump performance: a systematic review and meta-analysis. *BMC Sports Sci Med Rehabil.* 2023;15:103. doi:10.1186/s13102-023-00713-4.

THE SHORT VERSION

THE WHOLE GUIDE IN SIX LINES.

OUTCOME FIRST. Define the outcome before you pick the exercise.

READ THE PERSON. Use the six context domains for the person and the program.

GRADE IT. Grade the decision with IAOE. Adequate is a win.

READ THE EXERCISE. Use the eight domains. Weigh only what matters here.

KEEP IT SIMPLE. Choose the simplest option that meets the need.

WATCH AND ADJUST. Change the prescription first. Change the exercise when the selection is the problem.

THE EXERCISE IS ONLY PART OF THE DECISION.

Built from coaching experience. Organized for coaches who want a more consistent standard.

THE TRAINER'S COACH VAULT

EXPLORE THE TRAINER'S COACH VAULT.

You now have a framework for evaluating exercise characteristics, understanding the individual and making a defensible selection. The next challenge is applying that standard consistently across clients, phases and programming problems. The Vault expands these principles into coaching systems, decision tools and professional development resources.

VAULT.JRSTRENGTHANDFITNESS.COM

**BUILT ON STANDARDS.
PROVEN THROUGH EXECUTION.**

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